achieved replacement levels of TFR. This momentum of increase in population will continue for some more years because high TFRs in the past have resulted in a large proportion of the population being currently in their reproductive years. It is imperative that the the reproductive age group adopts without further delay or exception the *"small family norm"*, for the reason that about 45 percent of population increase is contributed by births above two children per family.

- *Higher fertility* due to unmet need for contraception (estimated contribution 20 percent). India has 168 million eligible couples, of which just 44 percent are currently effectively protected. Urgent steps are currently required to make contraception more widely available, accessible, and affordable. Around 74 percent of the population lives in rural areas, in about 5.5 lakh villages, many with poor communications and transport. Reproductive health and basic health infrastructure and services often do not reach the villages, and, accordingly, vast numbers of people cannot avail of these services.
- High wanted fertility due to the *high infant mortality rate* (IMR) (estimated contribution about 20 percent). Repeated child births are seen as an insurance against multiple infant (and child) deaths and accordingly, high infant mortality stymies all efforts at reducing TFR.
- Over 50 percent of girls marry below the age of 18, the minimum legal age of marriage, resulting in a typical reproductive pattern of *"too early, too frequent, too many"*. Around 33 percent births occur at intervals of less than 24 months, which also results in high IMR.

## HIGHLIGHTS OF THE CENSUS-2011

The major **highlights** of the Census 2011 are as under:

- The **population** of the country is 1210.19 million of which 623.72 million (51.54%) are males and 586.46 million (48.46%) are females.